Behind the Veil

The controversy around students wearing the hijab has sparked a larger debate centred around cultural dress codes, institutional authority, personal choice and bigotry



ZAFARUL-ISLAM KHAN
An Islamic scholar, Khan studied at Al-Azhar (Cairo) and has a PhD in Islamic Studies from Manchester University. His English translation of the Quran is slated for a 2022 release.

MODESTY & MODERNITY

In Islam, both men and women are required to dress modestly and follow certain norms to uphold a moral social order. In common usage, the word 'hijab' (Arabic for veil) is used to refer to a head scarf—often a part of modest attire. The term itself has more metaphorical range, broadly denoting the modest dress code Muslim women should observe in the presence of men outside their immediate family. The veil is not unique to Islam—versions of it can be found in ancient civilisations, Semitic religions and Hinduism, as well as in pre-Islamic Arabia, where it was used to differentiate 'free women' from slaves. In the Quranic context, the hijab encourages modesty, both physical and spiritual.

The actual guidance in the Quran directs Muslim women to cover their whole body, except hands and face: "believing women...should lower their gaze and guard their chastity; they should not display their beauty [and ornaments] except what [ordinarily] appears thereof; they should draw their scarves over their neck-openings and not display their beauty..." (24:31, author's translation). The Quran uses the word 'khimar', meaning a piece of cloth covering the head—local names like chador refer to its variations. A stricter form of hijab, covering the whole body, including the face, and limiting interactions with male strangers, was promulgated only for the 'Mothers of the Faithful', i.e. the wives of Prophet Muhammad (33:32,53). They were held to a higher standard, and believers were enjoined to speak to them from behind a veil or curtain.

In Islam, both men and women must cover certain parts of their bod-